

Amendment No. 1 to SB0554

Crowe
Signature of Sponsor

AMEND Senate Bill No. 554

House Bill No. 510*

by deleting all language after the caption and substituting:

WHEREAS, this State recognizes the vital role of physicians in ensuring the health and well-being of its citizens; and

WHEREAS, access to quality medical care is essential for the prosperity and vitality of our communities; and

WHEREAS, this State, like many other states, is facing a growing shortage of physicians, particularly in rural and underserved areas; and

WHEREAS, this shortage threatens to undermine the State's healthcare system and jeopardize the health of Tennesseans; and

WHEREAS, this looming crisis is driven by a complex interplay of factors, including an aging physician workforce, increasing population demands, and a decline in the number of physicians entering primary care and other critical specialties; and

WHEREAS, physician burnout, exacerbated by administrative burdens, regulatory complexities, and increasing demands on their time, is contributing to early retirement and career changes; and

WHEREAS, the moral injury experienced by physicians, stemming from their inability to provide optimal care due to systemic constraints and resource limitations, further compounds the problem; and

WHEREAS, this State acknowledges the urgent need to address this physician shortage and ensure access to quality health care for all Tennesseans; now, therefore,

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 68, Chapter 1, is amended by adding the following as a new part:

68-1-1701. Short title.

This act is known and may be cited as the "Tennessee Physician Workforce Information Act."

68-1-1702. Duties of the department of health.

The department shall:

(1) Contact qualified medical organizations in this state and request the following information from such organizations:

(A) Perceived strengths and weaknesses or concerns of physicians practicing in this state;

(B) Opportunities for improvement in policy to recruit and retain physicians or maintain physician practices;

(C) Threats to a physician's practice or patients;

(D) The impact of physician burnout, moral injury, and administrative burdens on the physician workforce;

(E) The effectiveness of existing programs and initiatives aimed at addressing physician shortages;

(F) Opportunities to enhance medical education and training programs in this state to attract and retain future physicians;

(G) The potential for telehealth and other innovative approaches to expand access to care in underserved areas;

(H) Physician turnover related to employment conditions; and

(I) Information regarding subdivisions (a)(1)(A)-(H) from such organization's national affiliates;

(2) Compile the information pursuant to this section into a written report;

and

(3) Submit a preliminary and final report as described in § 68-1-1703.

68-1-1703. Reporting requirements.

(a) On or before December 31, 2025, the department shall submit the preliminary report and an update on the progress of the final report to the chairman of the health and welfare committee of the senate and the chairman of the committee in the house of representatives having jurisdiction over health-related matters.

(b) On or before December 31, 2026, the department shall submit the final report to the chairman of the health and welfare committee of the senate and the chairman of the committee in the house of representatives having jurisdiction over health-related matters.

(c) The preliminary and final reports must include the list of participating organizations and the findings or recommendations from the participating organizations.

(d) As used in this part, "department" means the department of health.

SECTION 2. The headings in this act are for reference purposes only and do not constitute a part of the law enacted by this act. However, the Tennessee Code Commission is requested to include the headings in any compilation or publication containing this act.

SECTION 3. This act takes effect upon becoming a law, the public welfare requiring it.